

by everyone, without any barriers. However, Web pages pose many barriers to persons with disabilities because Web developers are not aware of the accessibility principles. This article gives a few suggestions on how websites can be made more accessible to the elderly and to people with disabilities.

Web accessibility myths

There are certain myths about Web accessibility that need to be cleared first to build awareness among Web developers.

- **Myth 1:** Persons with disabilities cannot access the Web and even if some of them do, their numbers are so marginal that there's no need to make an effort to make the Web accessible to them.
- **Myth 2:** If we design Web pages to make them accessible to persons with disabilities, then the site will not look professional.
- **Myth 3:** It would take huge amounts of time and effort to build accessible Web pages.
- **Myth 4:** Making Web pages accessible is not mandatory.

Compelling reasons for Web accessibility

To dispel these myths, let's explore some of the compelling reasons for making Web pages accessible.

- Persons with disabilities make up the largest invisible minority in the world. As per the WHO (World Health Organisation), there are more than 1 billion people with disabilities across the globe, which constitutes 15 per cent of the world's population. Every seventh person in the world has some sort of disability. This means that we have a significant number of users who can't be ignored.
- 'Accessible Web pages' doesn't necessarily mean these pages should be devoid of fancy design elements. On the contrary,

Table 1: Accessibility related policies and regulations

Country	Regulation/Law
India	Guidelines for Indian Government websites, RPwD Act 2016
United States	Section 508 of the US Rehabilitation Act
United Kingdom	Equality Act 2010
Finland	Act on Electronic Services and Communication in the Public Sector
France	General Accessibility Framework for Public Administration
European Union	Web and Mobile Accessibility Directive
Italy	Stanca Act

pages that are designed based on universal design guidelines look more professional and may attract more visitors.

- Accessibility has been made mandatory with the introduction of laws such as the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016 (RPwD Act 2016). In India, with the launch of pioneering projects such as Digital India and the Accessible India Campaign, the need for building an inclusive digital ecosystem becomes all the more important.
- Incorporating basic accessibility features in your Web pages is not a daunting task. Considering the benefits of inclusion, which means more visitors to your site, it makes business sense to put in the effort to be accessible.
- Even ethically, it is a best practice not to exclude any group of users.

Accessibility standards

Various countries across the globe have introduced laws and regulations related to accessibility. A sample list is provided in Table 1.

If you want to explore the complete list, you can go to <https://www.w3.org/WAI/policies/>.

Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG)

Though there are country-specific regulations, the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) has developed a standard set of guidelines termed as Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG). The WCAG has been developed in cooperation with accessibility experts, users and organisations across the globe so that a standard set of guidelines can be evolved.

The current version of WCAG is version 2.1, which was published in June 2018. WCAG has three levels of

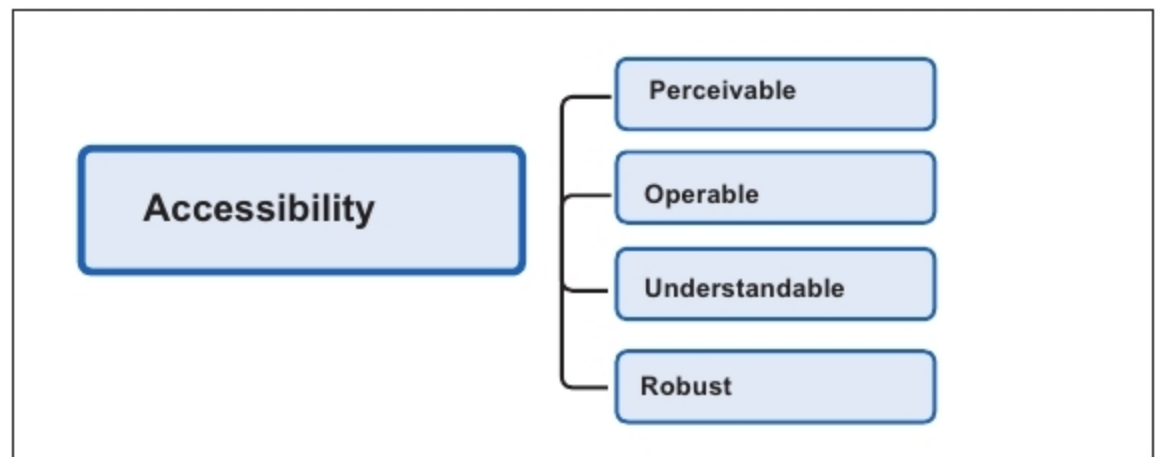


Figure 1: Accessibility principles